

What else to watch: *The Rules of the Game* (1939, pp.60-61) ■ *Divorce Italian Style* (1961) ■ *The Exterminating Angel* (1962) ■ *Pierrot le Fou* (1965) ■ *Belle de Jour* (1967, p.336) ■ *The Ruling Class* (1972) ■ *Amarcord* (1973)

Buñuel is not remotely concerned with conventional narrative flow. Intercut with the frustrated efforts of the dinner guests are dream sequences that pop from their heads and sometimes overlap with each other, as well as skits involving prop food, flashbacks, and at the center of it all, the ambassador to the Latin American Republic of Miranda (entirely fictional), who finds himself drawn into a bizarre terrorist plot.

Class and convention

Dinner is the occasion on which the social elite can come together to display their taste, refinement, and material wealth. It assumes a symbolic place far ahead of anything else in these people's lives. The party's snobbery and superficiality are continually

satirized through the movie as, for instance, the bishop is thrown out when he is mistaken for a mere gardener, then welcomed fawningly when he returns in his episcopal vestments.

Road to nowhere

Even as the world crumbles around them and everything begins to fall apart, the six friends are determined to press on with their dinner, and no obstacle, no matter how absurd, will stop them. Throughout the movie, the six are often seen striding purposefully down a seemingly endless road through the



The poster for the cinema release had a suitably surrealist design in the style of Belgian painter René Magritte.

countryside, a metaphor for their hollow obsession with status.

Buñuel won the Oscar for best foreign picture for

the movie, and many directors acknowledge its influence. Its message about the self-obsession of the well-to-do is as relevant as ever, and the inventiveness of Buñuel's playful vision remains hugely fun. ■

“You’re **better** suited for **making love** than for **making war**.”

Rafael Acosta / The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie

In one of the movie's digressions, a soldier tells how he poisoned his stepfather as the ghosts of his real father and mother looked on.

